

despite its pro-middle class economic reforms. In the 2004 elections, at the peak of the India Shining campaign, the party lost 42 of the 56 urban constituencies it had won in 1999.

Most of the second rung leaders in the BJP see Rajnath as a rival. There are periodic rumours of him being replaced, either by Advani or more recently by former Vice-President Bhairon Singh Shekhawat. When asked to comment on this, a general secretary remarked caustically that, "rest assured both Manmohan Singh and Rajnath will complete their full term". To build his own team, as his predecessor did in the 1980s, Rajnath is turning to the relatively inexperienced third rung leadership that lacks the finesse of the Advani brigade—both in terms of planning elections and handling the media. In this day and age, it is the latter that has the edge. To counter the prime minister's allegations of BJP leaders holding *havans* for his death, it was general secretary Arun Jaitley who drafted the party's reply at Advani's behest. Again it was Advani



PARTY POLITICS: Gen Next leaders are still to accept Rajnath's supremacy

who often shoots off his mouth, at the best of times, Rajnath is hesitant to speak his mind.

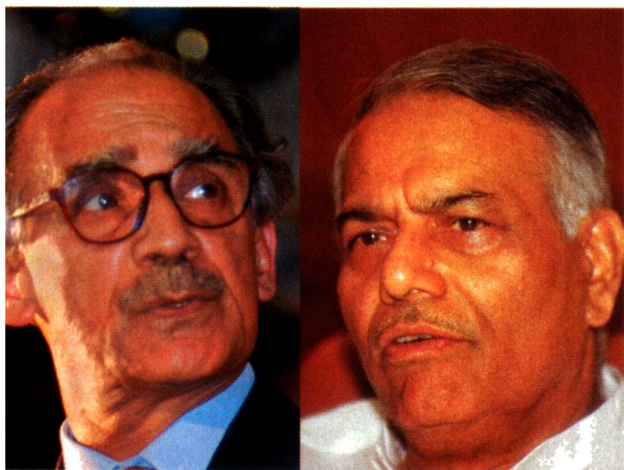
True to form, Rajnath was noticeably silent on the Patil issue, but then so was Vajpayee. This is not the first time that Rajnath has veered towards Vajpayee as a role model rather than

the role of a political seer.

Both Advani and Rajnath, while committed to the RSS ideology, appear divided on the means to achieve the end—revival of the party's fortunes and improving its electoral chances. Advani believes the party needs a new mantra or an ideological diversion to woo middle class India and the majority community back to the BJP.

Two years ago, he embraced Jinnah to reach out to those who were passionately pushing for cordial Indo-Pak relations. But it isolated him from the rank and file and from the very same people who are now urging him to pursue a pro-US line. On the other hand, leaving Advani to handle the media and the metropolis, Rajnath has been criss-crossing the country, addressing workers' meetings. The party chief prefers to build the party from the grassroots level and pursue a hardcore Hindutva line. But at the same time, Rajnath has done little to assert himself as the party chief except setting up committees and reshuffling the organisation. Managing the BJP rather than leading it.

Unlike Vajpayee who has lived out all his dreams, Advani's ultimate ambition still remains unfulfilled. Yet, along with Vajpayee, he remains one of the twin towers of the party. One's place in history is assured, while the other knows where he wants to be positioned but has also a slight suspicion that he just may not get there. ■



CAUGHT UNAWARES: Shourie and Sinha had no clue about Advani's plans who took charge of the campaign against Pratibha Patil during the presidential elections. He spearheaded the entire attack, with his former aide Sudheendra Kulkarni organising a press conference against her. And when a thinktank launched a website whose sole purpose was to run down Patil, the function was not held at the BJP headquarters but at Naidu's residence. Unlike Advani,

Advani's views on the Indo-US nuclear deal were not in consonance with the official stand taken by the party.

Advani. His style of consensus politics is patterned on Vajpayee's way of functioning rather than Advani's confrontationalist approach. The irony here is that in his anxiety to market himself as the NDA's next prime ministerial candidate, Advani is attempting a makeover to morph into Vajpayee. The Jinnah controversy and his current comments on the deal are simply bids to repackaging himself. Unfortunately, both backfired. He just does not have the presence to carry off